

SHALESH RAVAL



"Modi is our party mascot. Nothing sells like him. His rivals have used every single weapon to dislodge him but his popularity remains high."

Adding fuel to 'Modi mania' were some party workers who recently presented a memento to Minister of State for Power Saurabh Patel at Vallabhipur. The occasion was his birthday on which he was gifted a trophy depicting Modi as Lord Krishna, Patel as Arjun and Gujarat BJP chief Purshottam Rupala as Yudhishtira a la Mahabharata.

There were rumours that Keshubhai Patel had been shown leading a pack of Kauravas in the memento. This back-fence talk was condemned both by all party workers cutting across factions. Modi, however, condemned his depiction in divine garb saying, "How can I compare myself with God? Lord Krishna is my icon and I draw the greatest inspiration from him. Can I ever pay such disrespect to



"Modi is obsessed with himself. He takes the credit even where he's done nothing."

G. JADAPHIYA, REBEL BJP MLA

MODI MANIA: In Surat, traders gave Modi T-shirts to the youth (left); the war chariot trophy (below) him?" Senior BJP leader Arun Jaitley went into defensive and stated that those involved in depicting Modi as Lord Krishna were not from the party.

But the charges of Modi building a personality cult around himself continue to fly thick and fast, also revolving around a film called *Mukhyamantri* (chief minister) while the Gujarati version is called *Gujarat no Naath* (Gujarat's saviour). The film, being made by a Modi supporter at a cost of Rs 2 crore, will be reportedly released on the eve of the coming polls. Akhilendra Mishra plays Namo Narayan Jogi—a takeoff on Modi—in the film. Popular Bollywood 'villain' Shakti Kapoor plays Arjun Modhvadia, who is the leader of the Opposition in the state Assembly. The Congress is threatening to ban its screenings if Modhvadia is portrayed in a negative manner. But the writer-director of the film, Ajitsinh Jhala, says the film is about how a chief minister wins over people by his just and vision-oriented governance. "I'm making the film from the core of my heart," says Jhala. "It will show the audience how a chief minister should be."

Another promotional medium adopted by Modi is DVDs showcasing his achievements and his nationalism being aired on local tv. Thirty-two DVDs have been planned, out of which 10 are already out and the remaining will be released by October 2. The pick of the DVDs, however, is a 40-minute film titled *Pragati ke Paanch Varsh* (Five Years of Progress). The film shows a non-resident Gujarati man visiting his home state after five years with his girlfriend and getting floored by the developmental strides that the state has made and the responsive governance he sees. This is enough to lure him back permanently and start his own business in the state. Says Dhiren Avashiya, an audio-visual expert in Modi's office who played a key role in the making of the DVDs, "*Vande Gujarat* captures the change Gujarat has seen in the past five years and seeks to put the chief minister's vision in proper perspective."

With the Assembly elections in sight, the Modi publicity machine has truly placed itself in top gear. ■